6 MESSAGES THAT GET ANSWERED AFTER HOURS, AND ONE THAT ANSWERS ITSELF

What to send your manager at 6 pm

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1 Put the deadline in the first line

After hours, the first line is the whole message. If it has no time in it, it waits for morning.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Hey, got a sec?"
> Instead say: "Need a yes or no by 9 am on one thing."

Time first, always.

2 Ask the question, not for permission to ask

"Can I ask you something?" costs a round trip. Ask the thing.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Quick question when you're free."
> Instead say: "Ship Friday without the export, or hold to the 21st with it? I lean ship."

The question is the message.

3 Give your lean so they can just agree

A thumbs-up is the easiest reply there is. Make it enough.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "What do you think we should do?"
> Instead say: "I lean ship. Thumbs up and I'll tell the team."

Make the answer one tap.

4 Say what you'll do if you hear nothing

This is the line that makes the message answer itself.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Let me know!"
> Instead say: "If I don't hear back by 9, I'll go with ship."

Silence gets a default.

5 Keep it to three lines

A wall of text at 6 pm is read at 9 am. Three lines are read at 6:03.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "(12 lines of context)"
> Instead say: "Need a yes/no by 9 am. Ship Fri without export, or hold to the 21st? I lean ship; if silent by 9, I ship."

Three lines, done.

6 The default line

This is the one on page 2. It turns every unanswered message into a decision.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Just checking you saw this?"
> Instead say: "Going with ship unless you say otherwise by 9. Told the team it's pending your word."

Say the default and the time. Then act on it.

Check before you send it

- [ ] Is the time in the first line?
- [ ] Did you ask the question itself?
- [ ] Did you give your lean?
- [ ] Is there a default if they're silent?
- [ ] Is it three lines or fewer?